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INTERVIEW
WITH ANIMESH

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Before he stepped out to compete at the 2025 Federation Cup in Kochi, Praveen Chithravel (**left**) wrote down something behind his numbered bib ahead of the start of the men's triple jump competition. Later, once he'd won gold while equalling his own national record of 17.37m, the 23-year-old revealed just what he had written:

'17.20m'

Chithravel had come in with high

expectations and ended up exceeding them at the Maharaja Stadium in Kochi. That was true for most of the competitions as well.

Conditions in Kochi were oppressive. Entry standards instituted for the first time meant there were fewer participants than in previous years. Also, some of India's top athletes weren't competing — double Olympic medallist Neeraj Chopra was training in South Africa, steeplechase record holders Parul Chaudhary and Avinash Sable were in the USA, as was Gulveer Singh, who holds records in the 5,000m and 10,000m. Despite all this, the 28th



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Fast track: Animesh Kujur (centre) won gold in the 200m event after setting a national record. R. K. NITHIN

edition of the Federation Cup more than served its purpose as Indian athletics' first major national-level competition of the 2025 season.

Two national records were set — by Animesh Kujur in the men's 200m, and Dev Meena in the men's pole vault. Another, by Chithravel in triple jump, was equalled. New stars began to emerge, while some prospects who had been struggling began to find form.

Chithravel's effort of 17.37m — achieved on his third attempt — was easily the strongest performance at the Federation Cup. Although it's still early in the year, only two jumpers have leapt further than him this season. By virtue of this performance, he has already qualified for the World Championships in Tokyo.

With three jumps still in hand, Chithravel, in all likelihood, could have improved on the 17.37. "It